

STANFORD GRADUATE SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT STANFORD GSB

"The majority of people who go to GSB do extraordinary things in ordinary jobs." Stanford's MBA Program is the most selective in the world. It has maintained the highest ratio of applicants to available seats of any business school in the U.S. for the last decade. It has also had the lowest acceptance rates of any major business school in the world. Accepting only 6% of those who apply for admission yield is over 93%. No school is more choosy than Stanford.

The Stanford MBA class size is less than half the size of Harvard. And with Silicon Valley in its back yard a growing number of tech and engineering applicants are choosing the GSB over their East coast rival. The small class size lends itself to an intimate and close-knit community environment and pretty much guarantees that almost every student knows each other. Its motto is "Change Lives Change Organizations Change the World."

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

As you might expect from one of the world's top business schools Stanford's MBA program is known for its strengths across many areas in particular entrepreneurship, innovation, finance, technology general management and social enterprise.

KEY STATS

MBA

RANKINGS*

	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	5	-	-	-	4	7	2	5	1	1
Financial Times	4	4	2	2	2	4	2	4	1	1
Forbes	-	2	1	1	-	1	-	2	-	2
The Economist	7	8	9	9	9	13	5	5	5	7
US News	1	1	1	1	1	1	2	4	4	2

CLASS OF 2021 ADMISSIONS

Number of Applicants	7342	Avg Work Experience	4.6 years
MBA Class Size	419	Avg GMAT	734
Yield	94%	Avg GPA	3.7
Total Tuition	\$149,412	Int'l Students	42%

POST-MBA CAREERS (CLASS OF 2019)

Financial Services	33%
Consulting	18%
Technology	24%
Starting a Business	15%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, Google, Cisco, Bain, BCG, Microsoft, Apple

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: **US\$144,455**

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: **95%**

*Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR STANFORD GSB APPLICATION

BY MATT SYMONDS

Considered to be one of the most influential voices in business education, Matt Symonds is the first point of contact for many of our clients and brings a truly unique level of insight to business school selection. Bestselling author of *Getting the MBA Admissions Edge*, sponsored by McKinsey, Goldman Sachs, BCG and Bain, he writes about the MBA for *Forbes*, *The Economist*, *BusinessWeek*, the BBC, and *AméricaEconomía*. His in-depth industry knowledge makes him a much sought after guest on television, radio, in the press and at conferences.



Rather than indulging in heavy self-promotion to blow away the competition, striking a humble tone with thoughtful illustration is the best way forward.

1

DEFINING CHANGE

There are not many institutions in the world that can get away with the tagline "Change lives. Change organizations. Change the world." So when it comes to defining your career goals, you should bear in mind that the admissions office is seeking individuals who are looking to have real impact, whether professionally or in society. The selectivity of the business school means that they can look beyond students whose goal is to secure a place in a strategy consulting firm or investment bank, and identify those applicants who are driven by a desire not just to excel in their careers but also to help others and have a positive impact. As you think about your own post-MBA career goals, include a longer-term view about the areas where you think you can affect real change.

YIELD AND THE IMPORTANCE OF FIT

2

A yield above 80% suggests that the GSB admissions team is very good at identifying those applicants who have a strong fit with the culture and values of the school. Successful applicants not only have academic pedigree, stellar GMAT scores and personal and professional accomplishments to their name. They also have integrity, the ability to open up, be vulnerable, and grow in a supportive yet challenging environment. As such, the Admissions office works very hard to bring together a group of students who are open, humble and have strong integrity and this provides the foundation of the level of camaraderie and trust that you find at the school. Does that sound like you? Then share your story with the school in a natural, genuine way.

3

CAREER GOALS

Pretty much all of the leading business schools can all open the door to McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Goldman and Morgan Stanley. Only 19% of the Stanford Class of 2019 went in to consulting and 5 times as many secured a place in private equity or venture capital as investment banking. Many are starting a new business many of them in the technology sector. The school likes you to dream big while demonstrating that your goals and career vision are viable given your track record of achievement and excellence.

CONTRIBUTING TO LIFE ON "THE FARM"

4

For a program that consistently ranks among the top 2 or 3 in business school rankings, the Stanford MBA does not need to hear from you how wonderful it is. The brand and reputation of the school speak for themselves. But you do need to show your passion and absolute commitment to the school. The admissions team wants to understand how you can contribute to the Stanford community, and how the education you receive will provide the knowledge and skills to make the difference in your career. A campus visit, attending an info session and reaching out to students and alumni are all opportunities to better familiarize yourself with the distinct personality of the school.

So take the time to research the many clubs and organizations available at both the business school and the wider Stanford University campus, 'The Farm', and think about how you can bring energy and engagement outside the MBA classroom. There is no perfect candidate, so be honest about the areas in which you can improve, and how you hope to make the most of your two years in Palo Alto.

5

AUTHENTICITY AND HUMILITY

With 17 applications for each place in the MBA program at the Stanford Graduate School of Business, it is no surprise that candidates feel enormous pressure to stand out in the crowded applicant pool by producing impressive application essays and letters of recommendation for their admissions file.

But you can go too far in a bid to secure your place, and replace authenticity and self-confidence with boastfulness and arrogance. The Assistant Dean of MBA Admissions acknowledges that boastfulness can be an easy trap to fall into when candidates spend their time worrying how they compare to other applicants. But he states that personal humility is not inconsistent with professional ambition and professional drive. And humility is certainly one of the traits the GSB is looking for in its admits.

So while there are many approaches to creating a compelling application, there is clearly an appropriate tone to strike in your application. Rather than pumping up your accomplishments in the hope of impressing the admissions reader, or indulging in heavy self-promotion to blow away the competition, striking a humble tone with thoughtful illustration is the best way forward.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

The school is looking not just for extremely bright and successful individuals, but also people who have strong values and want to have a positive impact in the world.



ESSAY 1. "What Matters Most to You and Why" (approx. 650 words)

This notorious essay is at the heart of the MBA application to the Stanford GSB, and typically ties applicants in knots as they try to come up with an answer that they hope is clever, striking, or even profound. The school is looking not just for extremely bright and successful individuals, but also people who have strong values and want to have a positive impact in the world. Taking the time to really think about this question provides invaluable insight about your life purpose and values, and the true you that emerges from this introspection helps the GSB to evaluate fit and diversity of contribution to the class.

To best tackle the structure of this essay, start with identifying a person, event, or experience that greatly impacted you, and think about the morals, values, and lessons you gained from this experience or interaction. How do you use these lessons today, and how do they impact your drive, your motivation, and your vision of the world? This is a place to get personal and be courageous.

Even though you might have to spend hours on this essay through brainstorming, research, talking with others, writing a draft, then another (and then another), just remember that it's all inside you... it's your story, and you just have to find it and pull it out.

ESSAY 2. "Why Stanford" (approx. 400 words)

If the first essay is about your past and present, the second essay is about your future. Taken together, both required essays need to be coherent and could read as a single story. In this essay, Stanford asks you to explain your decision to pursue graduate education in management and the distinctive opportunities you will pursue at Stanford. Here, your

school research really needs to shine. What classes, clubs, events or other elements of the program and community will catalyze the impact you are aiming to make in the short, medium and long term? Dig deep and get specific, show Stanford that you've done more than just read the GSB website.

This is also where you should lay out career vision, in a highly focused and concise way. Beyond connecting the dots for your interviewer, you also really need to be specific to you. Look at every sentence and make sure no one else could have said it. Why do YOU need to be a better leader in what way? How is the Stanford MBA and its offerings uniquely positioned to help?

(OPTIONAL) ESSAY 3. "Think about times you've created a positive impact, whether in professional, extracurricular, academic, or other settings. What was your impact? What made it significant to you or to others? You are welcome to share up to three examples." (1,200 characters, or about 200 words for each example.)

Introduced for the first time in 2019, this short answer question is a valuable invitation to reveal where you've been most impactful with both substance and specificity (you'll do well not to consider it optional). Behind this question is Stanford GSB's belief that past behavior is the best predictor of future potential. It's very likely your examples will appear in other parts of the application: a bullet on the resume, a story used to support the recommendation – even on the application itself, which asks you to talk about your "most significant accomplishment" for each job. As such, this is your opportunity to GO DEEPER, not repeat

something that may be found elsewhere. Your responses need to add value to your overall application. They should support the essays and the rest of the application, in highlighting WHY you find each circumstance to be impactful.

(OPTIONAL) ESSAY 4. "Tell us about a time within the last three years when your background influenced your participation at work or school." (180 words)

In asking this question, the GSB seeks to uncover the less visible forces that shape candidates' lives, opportunities, decisions, and achievements. This optional essay is a way for the admissions committee to recognize the challenges – or privileges – certain applicants face to get to where they are, even when students themselves may not see them as distinctive or noteworthy. Like the required essays, answering this question in an authentic and compelling way requires a both substantial introspection and self-awareness. It's a recognition that up and beyond your test scores, transcripts, and career achievements, prospective students come from different backgrounds that shape their decision-making in invisible ways.

This question has always been part of the GSB app, but has been elevated from a field in the app to an optional essay. Think of it as a place to talk about an aspect of your life that hasn't been addressed anywhere else. It can also take a more lighthearted turn, touching on a sport you're involved in, your side gig in improv comedy, your training as a concert pianist – and how this has shaped how you show up in the workplace.

DEADLINES & DATES*

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	FINAL DECISIONS
Round 1	15 September 2020	10 December 2020
Round 2	6 January 2021	1 April 2021
Round 3	6 April 2021	20 May 2021

*COVID-19

For the latest updates about how COVID-19 is impacting admissions and programming at Stanford GSB and all top MBA programs, please visit our [blog](#).



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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